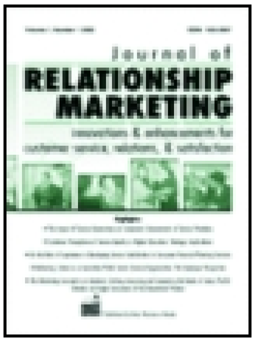

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The Genesis of Relationships: Boundary Spanners' Appraisals of the Career Entry Transition

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SUMMARY. Productive relationships between a company and its customers are often the result of positive relationships between the company and its boundary spanning employees. The career entry transition marks the beginning of these interpersonal relationships, which have a significant impact on marketing performance. Using a sample of newly hired boundary spanning employees, we examine the influence of individual difference factors on boundary spanners' appraisals of the career entry transition. Significant relationships are found between boundary spanners' positive and negative appraisals of the transition and personal and non-organizational factors: perceived centrality of the work role, availability of resources (finances, social support, personal hope), and sense of coherence.

KEYWORDS. Boundary spanners, career entry, transition, appraisal

Practicing marketing managers and scholars alike have long known that an important determinant of the nature of the employer-employee relationship is the employee's perceptions of the quality of his or her experience during the initial phases of the employment process (Jones & George 1998; Johnston et al. 1990). In the management literature, the study of this particular aspect of the employment process has been conducted primarily by human resource management (HRM) scholars. Traditionally, these scholars have viewed the quality of the employee entry transition process as affected by three distinct human resource functions: pre-entry activities such as the interview process; awareness and acceptance of the firm's expectations, norms, and culture provided by orientation activities; and the development and maintenance of relevant skills and knowledge provided by training and development initiatives (Mathis & Jackson 2001).

In terms of the above HRM functions, scholars have been successful in establishing empirical support for a link between each function and organizationally desirable outcomes. For example, realistic job previews–a type of interview designed to give potential employees a realistic picture of the job in question and the context in which it is performed–have been shown to result in lower levels of turnover (Philips 1998). Effective orientation programs help create favorable impressions of the organization and increase the likelihood of new employees being favorably accepted by existing coworkers (Nelson & Quick 1991). Additionally, strong orientation programs have been shown to be predictive of high levels of organizational commitment, high levels of job satisfaction, and low levels of absenteeism (Mathis & Jackson 2001). Finally, HRM scholars have established numerous important benefits of training and development programs. Such programs facilitate a more comprehensive career transition experience by employees. Among the benefits accruing from training and development programs are increases in productivity, reduction in errors, lower levels of turnover, and a reduction in the amount of required employee supervision (Mathis & Jackson 2001). In sum, then, it appears that the entry transition experience is a crucial antecedent factor for marketing performance, and several other important organizational outcomes; namely, stronger organizational commitment, higher job satisfaction, lower turnover, and increased productivity.

Although HRM scholars have established the importance of HRM functions on the entry transition experience, to date, the majority of research in this area has focused on organizational-level variables and their impact on employee appraisals of the transition experience. In contrast, relatively little research attention has been directed at understanding the potential influence of individual-level variables on employee perceptions of the entry transition process. Considering such factors will help complete our understanding of those elements that affect employees' entry transition experiences. For instance, the amount of social support–from external sources (family, friends) and internal work sources (peers)–an individual receives during the entry transition period will likely affect his or her evaluation of the transition experience. The purpose of this paper is to consider such individual-level variables and their impact on employees' perceptions and appraisals of the entry process. Specifically, this paper takes a broader view of the transition process by focusing on the career entry experience from the employee's perspective and by considering the influence of personal and non-organizational factors on subsequent appraisals of the transition.

In this examination of the career entry experience, particular attention is given to boundary spanners–marketing personnel that develop and monitor relationships with important constituents outside the organization. In short, these employees represent the organization in interactions with key stakeholders. As noted earlier, entry transition experiences have been shown to be predictive of subsequent levels of key attitudes, such as job satisfaction and organizational commitment.

A successful entry transition experience is especially important with regard to boundary spanners, since outcomes such as job satisfaction have been shown to have clear links with the satisfaction and loyalty of customers (cf. Griffith 2001). Understanding the factors that influence boundary spanners' appraisals of their entry transition experiences will benefit marketing scholars and practicing HR managers alike.

In the sections that follow, the impact of several individual-level variables on boundary spanners' assessments of their entrance into organizations is examined. First, a literature review and discussion of the variables used in the study is presented. In doing so, research findings in psychology, marketing, and management are drawn upon to advance hypotheses regarding the key factors that contribute to excellent entrance experiences. These hypotheses are then tested using data obtained from new hires in boundary spanning positions across a variety of industries. The paper concludes with a discussion of the results and summary of the contributions this paper makes to the marketing literature.

LITERATURE REVIEW

The boundary spanning function encompasses the activities of employees who develop and manage relationships with customers and other key outside parties (Griffin 2002). Examples include salespeople, industrial buyers, public relations representatives, service providers, customer service employees, top management, and marketing managers. For most companies, the actions, attitudes, and behaviors of their boundary spanning personnel are absolutely crucial to their success. Crosby and Evans (1990) argued that customers often have a stronger relationship with a company's representatives than with the company itself, and that the quality of relationships developed with customers is an important antecedent to a company's long-term success. Because a boundary spanner is often the primary contact point with customers, his or her attitudes about the company play an important role in the customers' satisfaction with and loyalty to the organization.

Although management and industrial/organizational psychology scholars have established that a strong causal link from job satisfaction to performance does not exist at the individual employee level (Iaffaldano & Muchinsky 1992), individual job satisfaction does significantly affect other key behaviors and attitudes. For instance, in a study of field salespeople, Babakus et al. (1999) found significant relationships between satisfaction and increased organizational commitment, and between satisfaction and decreased intentions to leave the organization. Satisfaction also influences behaviors and attitudes such as job involvement, absenteeism, and organizational citizenship or "helping" behaviors (Griffin 2002). In addition, some evidence suggests the average level of individual-level satisfaction among an organization's employees influences organizational-level outcomes, including company performance (Ostroff 1992). In sum, when employees feel good about their jobs, they are more likely to hold attitudes and engage in behaviors that will be beneficial to the organization. When those employees are boundary spanners operating in a marketing function, they are more likely to exhibit a range of behaviors that build strong positive relationships with customers. This gives incentive for managers to carefully cultivate the relationship between a company and its boundary spanning employees from the very beginning. Doing so requires an understanding of the career entry transition from the employee's perspective (Johnston et al. 1990).

Career Entry Transitions

Transitions take many forms across a person's lifespan. According to Cowan (1991), the root meaning of transition is derived from two Latin words meaning "to go across." Examples of major life transitions include marriage, career entry, new parenthood, divorce, and retirement. During transitions old cognitive/affective structures and behavior patterns are reorganized and new patterns are developed. According to Upcraft (1989), individuals in the midst of transitions attempt to accomplish two primary objectives: adapt to the demands of the new life state and bring the emotional elements temporarily associated with the transition under control by integrating them into ongoing decisions and behaviors. The process of leaving college life and taking on a work career is a major life transition and is often accompanied by a strong affective experience and substantial changes in individuals' perceptions of control and well-being. For example, Munton and West (1995) suggested that up to 50 percent of all relocation transitions have a significant negative effect on the subjective psychological well-being of employees and their families.

The concept of individual roles is central to our study of the appraisal process. Building on previous work by Biddle (1979) and Allen and van de Vliert (1982), we use the term "role" to refer to a set of behaviors associated with a person's position in a social system that has individualized meaning and is guided by societal assumptions and norms. A "role transition" is defined as the relatively permanent change by a person from one set of expected positional behaviors to another at role entry or exit, or when the expected behaviors associated with an existing role are drastically changed (Allen & van de Vliert 1982). Like other major life events, the career entry transition for new boundary spanners involves multiple role transitions (e.g., exiting college roles, moving geographically, losing friends but gaining others; Wanous 1992).

Career entry transitions are significant and costly events for companies as well as for boundary spanners. Companies work hard to find and keep quality employees. Employee turnover results in major costs to companies for hiring, training, and the period of adjustment (usually several months) when replacement employees are not yet productive (Futrell & Parasuraman 1984; Johnston et al. 1990). Unfortunately, employee turnover rates are at their highest among newly hired employees (Wanous 1992). If an organization can better manage the transition event for new employees, it is likely they will be able to reduce these costs.

If marketing boundary spanners have a negative transition experience, the costs to the organization may be substantial because of the critical relationships customers have with these company representatives. These costs go beyond the expense of finding and hiring a new employee and include losses from forgone sales, depleted goodwill, and spoiled relationships. Therefore, an examination of the entry transition process and the factors that may help companies have more successful entrances of new hires is warranted.

Appraisals of the Transition Process

Research in psychology has revealed that when people are confronted with a new or unusual circumstance, one of the dominant reactive cognitive functions employed is "appraisal." Appraisal has been defined as an evaluative process that determines why and to what extent a particular transaction between a person and his/her environment is benign, beneficial, and/or harmful (Lazarus & Folkman 1984). Mere knowledge that a transition has occurred does not yield insight into the complexity or meaning of the transition to the individual. Indeed, two people entering a company at the same time will experience and appraise the transition very differently depending on a complex interplay of personal, organizational, and non-organizational factors (e.g., Mowday, Porter & Steers 1982). Various factors related to transitions have been validated in research involving boundary spanners (Churchill et al. 1985; Singh 1998; Johnston et al. 1990). Lazarus and Folkman (1984) assert that the outcome of the appraisal process is the key to understanding an individual's response to the event and subsequent behavior. Thus, our focus is on understanding the factors that influence the appraisal process.

More specifically, we focus on boundary spanners' appraisals of their career entry transitions (i.e., the transition experience of newly hired employees). Previous research has established that the initial attitudes and perceptions of employees at the earliest phases of their careers strongly predict their future performance and turnover intentions (Buchanan 1974; Johnston et al. 1990). In a similar vein, Hrebiniak and Alutto (1972) found that the *anticipation* of trust among new employees leads to the later formation of attitudes such as organizational commitment. Because new hires have no history upon which they can evaluate the strength or quality of their relationship with a company, it is likely that their appraisals of the transition process into the company will have an important influence on later levels of trust, productivity, and organizational commitment.

We take a holistic perspective of career entry to boundary spanner positions, and view the taking on of a new career as a major life event for an individual on the same order as getting married, having a first child, or retiring. Certainly a company's training and orientation efforts help employees adapt to that particular organization, but the appraisal process begins much earlier, beginning with their assessment of the first point of contact with the company, extending through the interviewing and hiring decision, and continuing during the actual transition into a role with the company. In addition, the appraisal is not only influenced by organizational factors, but also most likely by a number of personal and non-organizational factors that operate on an individual during the entry transition. This is a component of the appraisal process that has traditionally been understudied.

Particularly for new employees, non-organizational influences on the appraisal process and subsequent outcomes include factors such as personal attitudes toward the work role, changes in the availability of time, financial, and social support resources for the person, the presence of other life events occurring at the same time, and individual difference variables such as sense of coherence. Operating apart from organizational factors, it is quite likely that these factors will alter the employee's appraisal of the transition process, and in turn influence the employee's morale, commitment, and tenure with the company. In addition, traditional measures of organization- and non-organization factors are often designed for current employees. In contrast, our interest is in newly hired employees.

Finally, we note an important aspect of entry process appraisals that is sometimes overlooked. Boundary spanners may have strong positive appraisals about certain parts of their transition (e.g., increased pay, status, and responsibility), and at the same time have strong negative appraisals about other parts of the transition (e.g., relocation, travel away from family, increased pressure and stress). If HR managers are to fully understand boundary spanners' appraisals, they must recognize both dimensions of the employee's evaluation.

HYPOTHESES

Because a boundary spanner's new role lies at the heart of the transition process, we first examine how perceptions of role centrality affect the transition process. A role is considered central to a person if it is strongly defended by the person, is bolstered by beliefs and values, and affects a wide range of the person's behaviors (Biddle 1979). For example, a new boundary spanner who has begun a job in a company that espouses values consistent with his or her own will experience greater role centrality. In contrast, a new boundary spanner who has accepted new employment simply as a means to a different end (e.g., paying the rent) will experience lower role centrality. Roles perceived to be more central to a person's self-definition will tend to be sought after, and entry to such roles is predicted to yield positive appraisals of the transition. In contrast, roles perceived as less central to a person's self-definition are likely to be enacted with little zest, and at times reluctantly, resulting in a negative appraisal of the transition. As mentioned above, we predict an impact on both positive and negative elements of the appraisal:

H_{1a}: Boundary spanners' perceptions of the centrality of their work roles will *increase* the *positive* appraisal of their career entry transition process.

H_{1b}: Boundary spanners' perceptions of the centrality of their work roles will *decrease* the *negative* appraisal of their career entry transition process.

Next, we predict the available resources a boundary spanner has will influence the appraisal process. Depending on the conditions under which the transition occurs, the transition may have different effects (George 1993). For example, boundary spanners who have access to resources that allow them to effectively cope with the stress that accompanies transitions (Goolsby 1992) will likely evaluate the transition more positively.

Stryker and Statham (1985) point out that under some circumstances, adding a new role to an existing role set can *add* important resources and flexibility, thereby reducing rather than increasing strain. For example, when new employees take on boundary spanning roles, increases in finances, social support at work, and a personal sense of hope about the future are likely to help mitigate the negative changes (Hunt, Chonko & Wood 1985) accompanying the transition (e.g., reduced free time, increased time away from home). We examine the effect of five potential resources, and predict that each will influence boundary spanners' appraisals of the transition process:

H_{2a}: Boundary spanners' perceptions of the availability of resources (time, finances, social support from friends and family, and personal hope) will *increase* the *positive* appraisal of their career entry transition process.

H_{2b}: Boundary spanners' perceptions of the availability of resources (time, finances, social support from friends and family, and personal hope) will *decrease* the *negative* appraisal of their career entry transition process.

Sense of coherence (SOC) is a multi-dimensional individual difference characteristic that acts as a buffer, or resistor, to the experience of role stress (Antonovsky 1979, 1993). There are three primary dimensions of sense of coherence. *Comprehensibility* is described as "the extent to which one perceives the stimuli that confront one . . . as information that is ordered, consistent, structured, and clear, rather than noise-chaotic, disordered, random, accidental, inexplicable" (Antonovsky 1979: 16-17). *Manageability* is the "extent to which . . . resources are at one's disposal which are adequate to meet the demands posed by the stimuli that bombard one" (Antonovsky 1979: 17). Finally, *meaningfulness* "refers to the extent to which . . . at least some of the problems and demands posed by living are worth investing energy in, are worthy of commitment and engagement, are challenges that are "welcome" rather than burdens . . ." (Antonovsky 1979: 18). According to Antonovsky, theory and research findings have established that these three components are "inextricably intertwined" (1979: 19) and that, all things equal, high levels in one aspect will result in high levels of SOC overall. Further, high levels of SOC imply that the individual is in a position to manage stressful situations more effectively than an individual low in SOC. Indeed, the high-level SOC employee is much less likely to perceive the stimuli as stressful in the first place.

Entry transitions that are perceived as being non-stressful are likely to be evaluated in positive terms. In contrast, highly stressful transitions are likely to be viewed negatively. Since individuals with high SOC are less likely to report (or even experience) the effects of work-induced stress than are low SOC workers, it stands to reason that high SOC employees will evaluate their career entry transition process more positively, and less negatively, than will low SOC employees. Therefore, we propose:

H_{3a}: Boundary spanners' sense of coherence will *increase* the *positive* appraisal of their career entry transition process.

H_{3b}: Boundary spanners' sense of coherence will *decrease* the *negative* appraisal of their career entry transition process.

METHODS

Sample and Procedure

Boundary spanners (N = 104) from a variety of industries were included in the study subject to two constraints: (1) they were ages 20-26, and (2) they had been working full-time nine months or less since graduation from a four-year college. These constraints allowed us to focus on recent, early post-college employment transitions. Recruiting subjects who met the requirements for the study was accomplished using alumni and career placement lists obtained from a Midwestern university and by requesting help from mid-sized companies in nearby metropolitan areas. The seven companies that participated were located in two states and represented major telecommunications, insurance, manufacturing, accounting, and retail firms. The final sample included employees engaged in a variety of boundary spanning functions: marketing, sales, corporate relations, and customer service.

Questionnaires were administered in person by the researchers to employees during lunch breaks in conference or seminar rooms under similar controlled conditions. Fourteen sessions were conducted in 11 locations. The questionnaire took approximately 45 minutes to complete, and each participant was paid $10 at the close of the session. As an added incentive, participants were given the opportunity to be entered in a drawing for one of five $100 gift certificates good at any store in their regional mall.

Measures

Appraisal. Appraisal was conceptualized as two unipolar constructs rather than as a single bipolar construct in order to assess the nature of positive and negative appraisals. This approach is consistent with previous research on the nature of affective states which asserts that positive and negative affect are independent constructs and should be assessed separately (Warr, Barter, & Brownbridge 1983). The measures of positive and negative appraisal were constructed using a combination of appraisal measures used in previous research (Fish 1986; Stone & Neal 1984). An initial appraisal instrument consisting of 20 items (11 positive and 9 negative; all anchored by "Strongly Agree" and "Strongly Disagree") was pre-tested with a convenience sample of student subjects who were asked to report their attitudes toward their upcoming entry into their career.

To verify that the positive and negative appraisal measures represented two distinct constructs (and were not merely opposites of the same construct), the 20 items were entered into a principal components factor analysis with a varimax rotation. Two factors emerged, both with eigenvalues greater than one. In addition, the skree plot strongly suggested retaining two separate factors. The internal consistency of each set of items was then examined. The reliability estimate of the 11-item positive appraisal measure was high (Cronbach's $\alpha = .93$), and the reliability estimate of the negative appraisal measure was acceptable ($\alpha = .73$).

Role Centrality. To determine each respondent's perceptions of the centrality of both their college role and their career role, a scale was developed from existing measures of attitude toward objects and attitude toward acts (Batra & Ray 1986; Maheswaren & Meyers-Levy 1990). Items were carefully selected based on their face validity and their appropriateness for the study sample. Participants were asked: "Please think for a moment about how you feel about working in your current job, and then indicate to what degree the following items reflect those attitudes and feelings." The eight items were: Meaningful, Relevant, Central, Essential, Valuable, Matters to me, Of concern to me, and Important to me. Respondents indicated answers on 7-point scales anchored by "Not at all" and "Very Much." The eight-item measure demonstrated high internal consistency for role entry (into career; $\alpha = .94$) as well as for role exit (from college; $\alpha = .90$).

Resources. Participants were given the following instructions: "Please indicate how you feel today about how available the following resources are to you." The availability of five key resources was measured: time, finances, social support (friends, family), and personal hope (Kobasa & Pucetti 1983; Luborsky et al. 1973; Stone & Neal 1984). Five 7-point scale items anchored by "I have little available" and "I have plenty available" were used to assess these resources.

Sense of Coherence. Antonovsky developed the Sense of Coherence (SOC) scale which has shown good reliability (high internal consistency and test-retest correlations) and convergent and discriminant validity (e.g., Antonovsky 1993). Sample items include: "Until now your life has had: No clear goals or purpose/Very clear goals and purpose"; and "Doing the things you do every day is: A source of deep pleasure and satisfaction/A source of pain and boredom." In the current study the scale demonstrated acceptable reliability ($\alpha = .78$).

Other Life Transitions. The presence of other life transitions may interfere with results obtained from examining the career entry transition. Therefore, the incidence of other transitions occurring within the last six months was measured and included as a control variable. This variable was assessed using the top twenty-five life event items from the inventory developed by Holmes and Rahe (1967) and Dohrenwend and Dohrenwend (1974). Respondents were asked if any of the twenty-five events (e.g., divorce, gain of a new family member, foreclosure of mortgage or loan, outstanding personal achievement) had occurred in the past six months, and if so, the perceived personal impact of the event. These items were measured on a five-point scale anchored by "Little impact" and "Great impact." A score for this scale was calculated and used as a control variable in the analysis.

ANALYSIS

Hypothesis 1a predicted that positive appraisals of a transition would be influenced by role centrality. Multiple regression analysis was conducted to test this prediction. In order to control for the possible influence of other major life events within the past six months and the centrality of the employee's prior college role, measures of these constructs were included in the analysis as control variables. As predicted, entering a highly valued and central work role is positively and significantly associated with positive appraisals of transitions into these roles. Hypothesis 1b predicted that appraisals of a transition would be more negative as the perceived centrality of the new role declined. The overall model is not significant, and therefore does not support this hypothesis. These results are presented in Table 1.

Hypothesis 2a predicted the extent to which the availability of five resources would increase the employee's positive appraisals of the transition. Hypothesis 2b stated that available resources would reduce an employee's negative appraisals. As predicted, personal hope significantly increased positive appraisals of the transition process; however, it did not reduce negative appraisals. As expected, the availability of financial resources reduced negative appraisals; but it did not increase

TABLE 1. The Effect of Role Centrality on Boundary Spanner Appraisals of Career Entry Transitions

	Positive Appraisals			**Negative Appraisals**		
	df	*Parameter Estimate*	*t-value*	*df*	*Parameter Estimate*	*t-value*
Presence of Other Life Events	1	0.27	1.97[a]	---	---	---
Work Role Centrality	1	0.78	12.45[b]	1	−0.01	−0.12
College Role Centrality	1	−0.03	−0.34	1	−0.14	−1.51
Source of Variation	*df*	*Sum of Squares*		*df*	*Sum of Squares*	
Model	3	89.70		2	1.91	
Error	100	54.95		101	81.47	
Total	103	144.65		103	83.38	
	$F = 54.41$ ($p < .0001$)			$F = 1.18$ ($p < .31$)		
	$R^2 = 0.62$			$R^2 = 0.02$		

[a] $p < 0.10$ [b] $p < 0.001$

positive appraisals. Time resources and social support from family did not influence positive or negative appraisals. Social support from friends did not reduce negative appraisals, and showed an unexpected negative relationship with positive appraisals. These results, presented in Table 2, provide partial support for Hypotheses 2a and 2b.

A boundary spanner's sense of coherence is also predicted to influence appraisals of the transition process. Although the conceptual underpinnings of sense of coherence are different than they are for the five resources discussed above, to maintain simultaneous controls among the variables, sense of coherence was included in the same analyses as were the five aforementioned resources. This approach also reduces the increased probability of type II errors resulting from conducting multiple tests. Thus, the results for the tests of Hypotheses 3a and 3b are also shown in Table 2. As predicted by H_{3a}, a boundary spanner's sense of coherence does increase his or her positive appraisal of the transition process. Also, as predicted by H_{3b}, sense of coherence reduces the negative appraisal of the transition process.

TABLE 2. The Effect of Resource Availability on Boundary Spanner Appraisals of Career Entry Transitions

	Positive Appraisals			**Negative Appraisals**		
	df	*Parameter Estimate*	*t-value*	*df*	*Parameter Estimate*	*t-value*
Sense of Coherence	1	0.54	3.69[c]	1	−0.26	−2.23[a]
Time Resources	1	0.02	0.43	1	−0.03	−0.73
Financial Resources	1	0.02	0.34	1	−0.12	−2.75[b]
Social Support Resources–Friends	1	−0.16	−2.47[a]	1	0.03	0.54
Social Support Resources–Family	1	0.06	0.68	1	−0.03	−0.41
Personal Hope Resources	1	0.28	2.98[b]	1	−0.00	−0.04
Source of Variation	*df*	*Sum of Squares*		*df*	*Sum of Squares*	
Model	6	39.25		6	12.85	
Error	97	105.40		97	70.53	
Total	103	144.65		103	83.38	
	F = 6.02 (p < .0001)			F = 2.95 (p < .011)		
	R^2 = 0.27			R^2 = 0.15		

[a]p < 0.05 [b]p < 0.01 [c]p < 0.001

DISCUSSION

Boundary spanners fill a critical marketing role in organizations. Their attitudes and behaviors have implications for the strength of customer relationships, the image of the organization, and the financial viability of the company. Prior research has documented numerous benefits arising from employees' positive evaluations of the organization. Most notably, empirical evidence exists that employee satisfaction is related to customer satisfaction and loyalty (Griffith 2001). In this study, we examined factors that influence boundary spanners' appraisals of the transition into the organization. To the extent that boundary spanners' appraisals are positive, these desired marketing outcomes may be expected.

In this study, we found that the centrality of boundary spanners' work roles increased their positive appraisals of the transition process, but did not decrease their negative evaluations of this process. This pair of findings may at first seem counterintuitive, but it lends support to the idea that positive and negative appraisals are separate constructs. In a classic study of employee motivation, Herzberg (1959) discovered that certain organizational factors mainly influenced job satisfaction while others primarily influenced job dissatisfaction. Role centrality may simply be a factor that influences positive appraisals of the transition process, but does not influence negative appraisals. Another possible explanation is that at least some negative aspects of the transition are to be expected. In other words, the transition involves "sunk costs" that the employee is willing to endure to secure employment. Role centrality, although it would increase the positive appraisal of the transition, would be unable to eliminate, or even reduce, these expected negative aspects (even when role centrality is extremely high). In any case, HRM and marketing managers should be aware that role centrality plays an important role in boundary spanners' evaluations as they enter the company. Based on our findings, managers who are able to enhance the perceived centrality of boundary spanners' roles during the transition process may increase the desired outcomes associated with positive appraisals.

Two of the five personal resources examined in the study influenced boundary spanners' appraisals as expected: personal hope increased positive evaluations and financial resources decreased negative evaluations. These findings provide some support for our basic argument that non-organizational factors play a role in the evaluations boundary spanners make as they enter the organization. Personal hope may have allowed boundary spanners to focus on the positive aspects of the new role despite the stress and strain associated with the transition process. Similarly, financial resources may have "buffered" boundary spanners from the negative facets of role transition. The total number of such resources available to the boundary spanner could potentially make a vast difference in his or her entry experience. Although personal resources are often beyond the control of organizational influences, managers may benefit from simply understanding the effects of personal resources, and potentially could make adjustments when the stress associated with entry transition overwhelms the personal resources available to new employees.

Unexpectedly, one personal resource, social support from friends, significantly reduced the positive appraisals boundary spanners make of the transition process. The reason for this is not entirely clear, but one explanation may be that the transition itself jeopardizes continued social support from friends. A new job with increased responsibilities, potentially in a new location, might impinge on existing social ties. Given that the sample of boundary spanners who participated in this study were recent college graduates, it may be that they have a strong circle of friends, but are unable to benefit from it, given the demands of the job. Social support from friends did not significantly increase negative appraisals, but the coefficient was positive.

Of all the variables included in the study, boundary spanners' sense of coherence had the strongest impact on transition appraisals. As predicted, sense of coherence significantly increased the level of positive appraisals and significantly decreased the level of negative appraisals. These results suggest at least two implications for HRM and marketing managers. First, anything that can be done to increase boundary spanners' sense of coherence as they complete the transition is likely to improve their appraisal of the process. For example, since we know that an important dimension of SOC is the extent to which the individual feels that he or she has the necessary resources to meet the demands of their new role (e.g., the manageability dimension), management would be wise to ensure that all new boundary spanners enter a work environment characterized by access to the type and quantity of resources needed to make the transition as smooth as possible.

Second, organizations may find it worthwhile to screen new applicants for boundary spanning positions based on their sense of coherence. Screening specifically designed to identify individuals' high in the meaningfulness aspect of SOC is likely to prove fruitful since these individuals tend to view stressful situations in a more positive light than do individuals who exhibit lower scores on this dimension. Indeed, these relatively stress-resilient employees will see such situations as challenges rather than burdens. Thus, use of the SOC scale might very well represent a valuable addition to the HR manager's collection of selection tools. Again, this is important because ultimately, the effects of employee attitudes will be displayed in enhanced or reduced marketing performance.

LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

Our results provide a glimpse at several factors that influence internal relationship management. Certainly other factors play a critical role in this process. Importantly, however, this study examined personal and non-organizational factors of a key set of organizational employees. Understanding the transition process of boundary spanners may help HRM and marketing managers avoid the consequences of negative transitions (e.g., turnover, dissatisfaction) and take advantage of the benefits of positive transitions (e.g., organizational commitment, employee satisfaction, customer satisfaction and loyalty).

Of course, our study is not without limitations. We examine the transition experience of a relatively specialized sample–recent college graduates in their early careers. This sample allows us to identify important aspects of the entry transition appraisal, but it does not allow us to generalize our findings to other types of employees, such as mid- and late-career boundary spanners who are moving to new jobs between companies or even within the same company. Another limitation to our findings is that we collected subjects' subjective perceptions of the various measures. Ideally, we would have assessed objective outcomes as well, such as performance and other visible behaviors. These outcomes would have been difficult to obtain, but more important, they may not have provided reliable information in our current sample. For example, assessing the performance of new employees as they climb the learning curve in their new jobs would likely produce a relatively unstable measure. Including this information would be more appropriate once performance levels stabilize.

In conclusion, we recommend three basic directions for future research. First, in contrast to prior research on the effects of transition appraisals, our study examined exclusively non-organizational factors. Therefore, future research that combines both organizational and non-organizational factors will help explain the relative influence of each set. Second, the permanence of the beneficial effects of positive transitions should be examined. Previous research has revealed that for salespeople, there is a curvilinear relationship between time in a work role and overall job satisfaction, with the most satisfied salespeople being those who have held their jobs for two years or less (Churchill et al. 1985). It may be that the benefits of positive transitions expire over time. A more complete study of boundary spanners at pre-entry, early employment, and later career phases would help answer this question. One strategy to pursue this goal is to follow the same employees longitudinally through these stages. Finally, we recommend the examination and development of institutional efforts, such as recruiting, selection and orientation programs, that are designed specifically to increase the likelihood of positive appraisals by key marketing personnel.

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